sic training by doctors to tackle emergencies in the event of a future Covid wave. From running primary and secondary institutions, RSS members are now venturing into setting up universities and institutions of excellence.

Coupled with this 'NGO style' activism is a focused effort to correct the image and perception of the Sangh. In the last decade or so, the RSS has quietly increased its outreach through a new activity, 'Vishesh Sampark', a reaching out to specific target groups. All senior functionaries including Bhagwat take time out to meet 'influencers' in society to explain the RSS cause. The RSS chief has reached out to leaders of Muslim, Christian and other communities, exhorting them to overcome prejudices and learn more about the RSS. Extending this further, the RSS has embarked on the task of reaching out to political, academic, intellectual, religious and social leaders in dozens of countries in an effort to address the disinformation challenge affecting its image makeover globally.

A new confidence is conspicuous in the once reticent organisation these days. This stems from the fact that the core mission that it has pursued for over a century—re-establishing the centrality of Hindu cultural and civilisational identity in India's national life—has now become a reality. Hindutva occupies national centrestage today. Senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi wants to call himself a Hindu; so does Mamata Banerjee, leader of the Trinamool Congress. Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal has made budget allocations to give senior citizens free pilgrimage rides to Ayodhya.

All this was inconceivable a decade ago. The dominant political discourse in India's post-independence decades was centred around secularism. Hindu, Hindutva and Hinduism were relegated to the fringes and dubbed communal. Hindu Mahasabha leader N.B. Khare's description of Jawaharlal Nehru as a "Hindu by accident" came to be identified with the mainstream polity all these years. A false notion of secularism equated with the rejection of Hindu identity as majoritarianism—and yet pandering to minorityism in the same breath— had become the dominant political discourse after independence.

That distorted notion of secularism, dubbed by many Hindutva protagonists as pseudo-secularism, has now been rejected by the majority of Indians. To call oneself a Hindu is no longer a matter of hesitation or shame. Even prominent Congress leaders are writing books about Hindu history and civilisation. The RSS must get credit for this.

THAT DISTORTED NOTION OF SECULARISM, DUBBED PSEUDO-SECULARISM BY HINDUTVA PROTAGONISTS, HAS BEEN REJECTED BY THE MAJORITY OF INDIANS

Every movement passes through four stages, as the saying goes, "First they ignore you, then they laugh at you. Then they attack you, then you win." Many movements lose steam during the first three stages. The RSS has successfully passed through all of them and emerged as part of the national mainstream, overcoming ridicule and rejection. Not many organisations have survived for a century. The RSS has not only survived but it has thrived.

Today, it has more than 50,000 *shakhas*, and RSS activity spawns across lakhs of villages in the country. One barometer for assessing its spread and influence could be the recent campaign for mobilising financial support for the Ram Janmabhoomi temple in Ayodhya. Started earlier this year, thousands of RSS cadre had reached out and secured support from over 130 million Indians, including people from all parties, social groups and even members of other religions like the Muslims and Christians. No other social organisation can claim such an expansive reach and connect with the ordinary masses.

As it nears its centenary and embarks on a course befitting its strength as well as the need of the changing times, the organisation is faced with some critical challenges. Although it has emerged as the fulcrum of Hindu civilisational reassertion, it is still subject to scrutiny and criticism. Its exponential growth has resulted not only in organisational spread but also in influence of its thought process, the latter many times higher than the former. In fact, the RSS outside the shakhas is much larger than inside it. And it is not necessary that the discipline found inside can be found outside too.

This puts greater onus on the RSS leadership. Mohan Bhagwat understands it. He faced sharp criticism from a section when he talked about 'the common DNA of all Indians' sometime ago. His original emphasis was on telling the Muslims that they were not alien to the cultural-civilisational life of this ancient nation. But when he reiterated recently that "the DNA of all the people of India from 40,000 years ago is the same as that of the people today", it was probably his response to those angry sections, and also a likely theme for the organisation in coming years.

There is widespread Hindu pride in India today, not necessarily against any other community or religion. There is also Hindu anger among some sections—a sense of persecution, genuine or otherwise—triggered by acts like proselytising and Islamic radicalism. While pursuing its centenarian agenda, the challenge for the RSS will be to find a balance between the pride and anger, ensuring that neither spills over. ■

Ram Madhav *is Member, RSS National Executive. He is also Member, Board of Governors, India Foundation*

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE